NITROUS OXIDE

Also known as balloons, laughing gas or NOS



Large, brightly labelled canisters like these are used to fill balloons.

What is it?

Nitrous oxide is a gas inhaled for a brief high. The effects usually last only a few minutes, but the harms can last much longer.

How is it taken?

Gas from pressurised canisters is often released into balloons and inhaled.

How can it affect you?

It can cause dizziness, confusion, poor judgement, loss of balance and slower reactions. People may faint, lose consciousness or have accidents. Direct exposure to pressurised gas can cause serious cold burns.

Longer-term harm

Repeated or heavy use can stop vitamin B12 working properly, damaging nerves and the spinal cord. This can cause weakness, numbness and sometimes long-lasting difficulty walking.

A short-lived high does not mean the risks are short-lived. Never drive after using nitrous oxide.

With kind support and funding from Action Together

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

Warning signs that need medical attention

Pins and needles or numbness in hands or feet; weak legs; stumbling or difficulty walking; poor balance; memory problems; or changes in bladder or bowel control.

What to do

Stop using nitrous oxide. If you have numbness, weakness or difficulty walking, get urgent medical assessment and tell the clinician about nitrous oxide use. Vitamin B12 tablets alone may not prevent or treat nerve damage.

Call 999 if someone collapses, is unconscious, has a seizure or has serious breathing difficulties. Do not let anyone drive while affected.

UK LAW

Since 8 November 2023, nitrous oxide has been a Class C drug when intended for wrongful inhalation.

POSSESSION for recreational inhalation: Up to 2 years in prison, an unlimited fine, or both.

SELLING OR SUPPLYING for wrongful inhalation: Up to 14 years in prison, an unlimited fine, or both.

DRIVING WHILE UNFIT THROUGH DRUGS: A minimum 1-year driving ban, an unlimited fine, up to 6 months in prison, and a criminal record.

Prison terms are maximum penalties, not automatic sentences. Legitimate uses remain lawful.

Why this matters to South Asian communities

A UK study of 119 patients with nitrous oxide-related nerve and spinal cord injury found that 68 (57%) were Asian or Asian British. These were selected hospital cases, not a national rate of use or admissions.

Stigma and fear of judgement can stop people asking for help. A calm, private conversation can make a difference.

Free local support in Rochdale

TURNING POINT / ROAR — Adult drug and alcohol support: 0300 555 0234

EARLY BREAK — Young people and families: 0161 723 3880

THE SALIK PROJECT UK — Community education and help finding support: contact@salikprojectuk.org

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: Home Office (2023) nitrous oxide guidance; GOV.UK drug penalties and drug-driving law; Mair et al., JNNP (2023).

With kind support and funding from Action Together